World literature

If there is one model of comparison that has come to the fore since the turn of the millennium, it is that of world literature. The term is hardly new, as we saw in the previous chapter: from Wieland and Goethe to Brandes and Posnett, it resonates
p. 99 across the 19th century as the *de facto* object of study for comparative literature. ↵ Throughout this time its horizons remained decidedly European, however, adumbrating a quasi-colonial vision of the world controlled by an imperial centre. It is only with the advent of the 20th century that world literature took a global turn.

Instructive examples of this development can be found at either end of the century in the contribution to debates on world literature of Bengali. In 1907, the poet and polymath Rabindranath Tagore (1861–1941) was invited to give a lecture to the National Council of Education in Calcutta. Tagore insisted on discussing not comparative, but *world* literature: the Bengali term *Vishwa Sahitya*, he contended, does much greater justice to the diversity of the Indian sub-continent, in part because it does not correspond to the foreign, European notion of comparative literature. Tagore rejects what he sees as the problematic Western emphasis on the ‘nation’, emphasizing rather the dynamic, interdependent nature of literature, which he views not as ‘the mere total of works composed by different hands’ but as a ‘part of man’s universal creativity’. Most of us, admonishes Tagore, think of literature in the manner of a ‘rustic’, parcelling out patches of land piece by piece. To this provincialism he opposes his concept of *Vishwa Sahitya*, understood as the ‘universal spirit’ manifesting itself through the verbal arts.

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Nearly a century later, another Bengali thinker proposed an alternative form of world literature. In her Wellek Lectures on the *Death of a Discipline* (2003), Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, whose concept of the 'subaltern' helped open up a debate in the 1980s about how best to give voice to minority cultures, outlines what one might term a postcolonial form of world literature: 'planetarity'. The standard models of Anglophone, Francophone literature, etc., can no longer serve in the post-cold-war era, suggests Spivak; what is now required is a version of comparison that takes into account the non-Western traditions of comparative literature, and that thus allows the 'Global South'—which is to say the less developed, poorer
p. 100 countries previously designated by such ↵ terms as 'third world'—to speak for itself, in its own languages, rather than via a centralized, metropolitan elite. Spivak's opposition of the planet to the globe recalls Tagore's opposition of 'world' to 'comparative': globalization suggests corporate control and standardization; the planet, on the other hand, is what we inhabit, 'on loan'. She does not cite him, but Spivak seems to echo Tagore's ecological metaphors; in the era of global warming and climate change, we are all interconnected in ways that go well beyond cartographic distinctions. World literature must become planetary literature.

The example of these two Bengali thinkers—and one could add others, such as the writer and critic Buddhadeva Bose or the historian Dipesh Chakrabarty—suggests that world literature has been revivified by expanding beyond its European origins. Chakrabarty's criticism of the 'historicist' approach to world development—in which capitalist Modernity originates in Europe and then spreads inexorably elsewhere—extends even to the construction of time, tethered as 'Eurochronology' is to a Greenwich, rather than to a global meridian. Certainly the evolution of comparative literature can be criticized in these terms, however noble (some of) its expansionist intentions may have been. All too often, the view from elsewhere has been a view from Europe.

Yet there is no reason why a genuinely intercontinental model of world literature should not be possible. India, in fact, serves as a striking counterpart to Europe, composed as it is of a comparable number of languages and sub-cultures. If a comparative approach to Indian literature emerged, in the 1980s, as a sub-field unto itself, one might equally sketch out comparative literatures for almost all the continents. In the postcolonial age, perhaps every continent requires, to paraphrase Virginia Woolf, a comparative literature of its own. The most influential models of world literature in the postwar era, even
p. 101 those that emerged from Europe, have aspired to this multipolar perspective. In numerous ↵ studies of Chinese and comparative literature, for instance, the prolific French sinologist René Etiemble (1909–2002) theorized what he called *littérature universelle*, working tirelessly to demonstrate the ways in which Asian and European literature explored common thematic and stylistic concerns. Etiemble's slogans—the Sartrean manifesto 'comparative literature is humanism', the disciplinary self-consciousness captured by his untranslatable book title *Comparaison n'est pas raison* (1963)—not only helped establish the postwar discipline in France, but also skewered the limited vision of the 'world' that continued to characterize much European thought. Building on the legacy of illustrious forebears such as Montesquieu and Voltaire, Etiemble showed how much the Parisians could learn from the Persians.

More recently, this French conception of global literature has been repurposed in sociological terms. Pascale Casanova's influential vision of *The World Republic of Letters* (1999) proposes not world literature, but 'world literary space' as the key term. Literary history and political history, while obviously related, are not the same thing: the wounded pride of one nation—she gives the example of German classical literature 'fighting back' against Napoleonic hegemony—asserts itself culturally where it cannot politically. A constant push-and-pull thus develops, whereby a supposedly 'lesser' literature seeks to establish its own identity by both irritating and imitating the dominant power. In Casanova's sociological terms, national literatures, and national writers, compete with each other for international legitimacy.

It goes without saying, of course, that literary theorists do the same thing. The development of theories of world literature, and indeed of comparative literature more generally, can be understood through exactly the same models that are applied to literature. Universalism, planetarity, republicanism: such metaphors describe both comparison and comparatist, competing for attention with ever more inflated concepts of how world literature *really* works. Even the much-remarked manifesto 'For

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↵ a world literature in French' (2007), signed by leading authors from Canada, Tunisia, Senegal, the Congo, and France, announced the death of Francophone literature and the birth of *littérature-monde* as a 'Copernican revolution'. Given such metaphysical claims, it is hard to see where the metaphors have left to go.

Perhaps this inflationary logic is why the most influential model to have emerged in recent years emphasizes world literature not as a stable canon of classic works, but as a 'mode of circulation and of reading'. From Gilgamesh to postmodernism, David Damrosch's *What is World Literature?* (2003) pursues the flow of creation, translation, and production into the literary works themselves, arguing that the texts that achieve 'world' status are those that build the process of circulation into their own reflective structure. For Damrosch, a text enters into world literature by a twofold process: 'first, by being read *as* literature; second, by circulating out into a broader world beyond its linguistic and cultural point of origin'. If global intellectual history teaches us that the universality of an idea can be assessed by the degree to which it is adopted in distant contexts, global literary history can apply a similar test to texts. Indeed, a work can move in and out of world literature, depending on how it is read in a given time; the most 'worldly' works, to use Said's term, are those that gain most in translation. Comparative literature, in this sense, is not so much a canon as a currency.

The language of commerce takes us back to the original Goethean conception of world literature, and forward to the major criticism of the term as it has emerged over the last ten years. As early as 1827, Goethe described world literature as 'the market-place where all nations offer their products', and he himself conceived the notion in part as a way of encouraging the international reception of his own work. From its inception, in other words, world literature has been as much a capitalist as a comparative concept, as much about selling books as scrutinizing them. The most widely discussed critical engagement with
p. 103 the term, Emily ↵ Apter's *Against World Literature* (2013), takes this insight as its starting point, arguing that universalizing models of comparison ignore the problem of what the French philosopher Barbara Cassin calls 'untranslatables' (examples of which, as explored in Cassin's *Dictionary of Untranslatables* of 2004, include terms such as *Heimat*, *saudade*, and *pravda*). In resisting translation, such terms also resist the capitalist logic of international standardization; crossing borders, to cite the great comparative cliché, is precisely what they do not do. No one can read all the languages, which means that for better or for worse foreign texts are translated not only into a language, but also into an idiom familiar to the major markets—with all the attendant risks of misunderstanding and homogenization. Here as elsewhere, then, translation remains the dirty little secret of comparative literature.

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